

# FIONA CHEN

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# HARVARD UNIVERSITY

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## Education

### Harvard University

Ph.D. in Business Economics, 2021 to 2027 (expected)  
*Visiting Student, Stanford Digital Economy Lab, 2026*  
M.A. in Business Economics, 2023

### Massachusetts Institute of Technology

B.S. in Mathematics and in Economics, 2021

## Fields

Labor Economics  
Personnel Economics  
Digital Economics and AI

## References

Lawrence Katz  
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Erik Brynjolfsson  
Stanford University  
[erikb@stanford.edu](mailto:erikb@stanford.edu)

## Affiliations

|                              |       |
|------------------------------|-------|
| Stanford Digital Economy Lab | 2026- |
| Social Finance Institute     | 2025- |
| Opportunity Insights         | 2021- |

## Job Market Paper

### Artificial Intelligence in the Firm: Bottlenecks in Software Production, with James Stratton

We study the impacts of AI coding assistants and agents on software engineering work, using a novel proprietary dataset from an engineering analytics platform, covering 300 million work events – including GitHub coding activity, Jira issues, and Google Calendar events – across 718 firms. We use a staggered difference-in-differences design, exploiting variation in firm-level adoption timing of AI coding assistants and agents. Both technologies increase coding productivity. However, productivity gains do not fully pass through to changes in software output or employment. For AI agents, this incomplete pass-through reflects a bottleneck from code review: review times increase, a larger share of code updates require revisions, and reviews involve more comments. We develop a model of software production to rationalize these results, in which AI affects both productivity and quality of intermediate outputs, and in turn can generate a review bottleneck and limit pass-through.

## Papers in Progress

### Task Assignment and Career Advancement, with James Stratton

Workers with the same job title often perform vastly different tasks – but how do differences in task assignment affect career advancement? We examine this question using data from an engineering analytics platform on tasks assigned to software engineers, merged with LinkedIn data on workers' career trajectories. Using an instrumental variables approach, we exploit quasi-random variation in task assignment arising from fluctuations in teams' task portfolios at the time workers join. Assignment to more complex tasks in the first quarter of employment significantly increases

the likelihood of promotion within two years, consistent with greater opportunities for human capital accumulation and ability signaling. We explore the role of task assignment in gender disparities, documenting substantial gender differences in task assignment and persistent gender gaps in promotion.

**AI as a Career Advisor**, with *Katelyn Cranney and Leo Saenger*

We examine the role of AI in the job search process in partnership with CareerVillage, a nonprofit organization that provides AI-powered career guidance through its conversational tool, COACH. Specifically, we study whether AI can improve career decision-making by facilitating structured self-reflection, helping workers understand and articulate their skills and preferences, and evaluate tradeoffs across career options. We begin by using observational data to characterize how workers use COACH, finding that many conversations center on self-reflection. We are currently conducting a randomized controlled trial with unemployed job seekers to estimate the effects of AI-assisted self-reflection on career decision-making, employment outcomes, and longer-run job satisfaction.

**The Labor Market Effects of AI: Current Evidence and Future Directions**, with *Erik Brynjolfsson and Bharat Chandar*

We synthesize the emerging theoretical and empirical literature on the labor market impacts of generative AI. We organize the empirical evidence into three broad approaches: adoption-based studies comparing early and late adopters, exposure-based studies comparing occupations with differing levels of AI exposure, and survey-based evidence on workers' and firms' responses to AI. While exposure-based studies generally document declines in employment in AI-exposed occupations, the evidence from adoption-based studies and surveys is more mixed. We develop a framework for interpreting these findings by distinguishing between anticipation effects, automation effects, and the roles of partial and general equilibrium adjustments.

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|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| <b>Policy Papers</b>            | <i>Shaping the Future of Work: Generative AI, Inequality, and Opportunity, The Social Finance Institute: Workforce and Economic Mobility Papers, 17 December 2025</i> |         |
| <b>Employment &amp; Service</b> | MIT Corporation (Board of Trustees), <i>Trustee</i>                                                                                                                   | 2021-26 |
|                                 | Social Finance, <i>Research Fellow</i>                                                                                                                                | 2025-26 |
|                                 | Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco, <i>Financial Supervision Intern</i>                                                                                            | 2019    |
| <b>Fellowships &amp; Awards</b> | Schmidt Sciences AI at Work Grant                                                                                                                                     | 2026    |
|                                 | Stripe Economics of AI Fellowship                                                                                                                                     | 2025    |
|                                 | J. Robert Beyster Fellowship, Study of Employee Ownership and Profit Sharing                                                                                          | 2025    |
|                                 | James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Fellowship in Inequality and Wealth Concentration                                                                                      | 2023    |
|                                 | Opportunity Insights Doctoral Fellowship                                                                                                                              | 2021    |
|                                 | Paul and Daisy Soros Fellowship for New Americans                                                                                                                     | 2021    |
|                                 | Phi Beta Kappa (5.0/5.0 GPA)                                                                                                                                          | 2021    |
|                                 | Rhodes Scholarship Finalist                                                                                                                                           | 2021    |
| <b>Research Assistance</b>      | Burchard Scholarship                                                                                                                                                  | 2019    |
|                                 | Harvard, RA to Winnie van Dijk, <i>Concentration in Rental Housing Markets</i>                                                                                        | 2022-23 |
|                                 | MIT, RA to Amy Finkelstein, <i>Blueprints for Universal Health Coverage</i>                                                                                           | 2019-20 |
|                                 | MIT, RA to David Autor, <i>New Frontiers: The Origins and Evolving Content of New Work</i>                                                                            | 2019-20 |
|                                 | MIT, RA to Frank Schilbach, <i>The Economic Consequences of Increasing Sleep Among the Urban Poor</i>                                                                 | 2017-19 |
| <b>Teaching</b>                 | Harvard Medical School, Causal Inference in Economics and Medicine, <i>Joshua Angrist</i>                                                                             | 2025    |
|                                 | Harvard, ECON 980B Education in the Economy, <i>Claudia Goldin and Lawrence Katz</i>                                                                                  | 2024    |
|                                 | Harvard, ECON 2330 History and Human Capital (PhD), <i>Claudia Goldin and Lawrence Katz</i>                                                                           | 2024    |
|                                 | Harvard, ECON 980X The Economics of Work and Family, <i>Claudia Goldin</i>                                                                                            | 2023    |
|                                 | Harvard, Math Camp: Econometrics (PhD)                                                                                                                                | 2023    |
|                                 | MIT, 14.75 Political Economy and Economic Development, <i>Benjamin Olken</i>                                                                                          | 2021    |
|                                 | MIT, 14.13 Psychology and Economics, <i>Frank Schilbach and Dmitry Taubinsky</i>                                                                                      | 2020    |

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|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| <b>Seminars &amp; Conferences</b> | INFORMS Annual Conference (Scheduled), INFORMS Manufacturing & Service Operations Management, Society of Labor Economists, Google, MIT FutureTech, Stanford Labor/Public Student Workshop, Stanford University Digital Economy Lab                              | 2026 |
|                                   | UC Berkeley Artificial Intelligence Research (BAIR) Laboratory, MIT Computer Science and AI Laboratory (CSAIL), Opportunity Insights Conference, University of Chicago Machine Learning in Economics Conference, Harvard Kennedy School Stone Scholar Symposium | 2025 |
| <b>Languages</b>                  | English (Native), Mandarin (Conversational), French (Basic)                                                                                                                                                                                                     |      |
| <b>Software</b>                   | Python, R, Stata, SQL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |      |